It is likely that we have not seen any major conflict among the BRICS members so far because they are still progressing along those paths that offer the least resistance.[99] The global financial governance system and its associated institutions need China for their own legitimacy and viability in the current uncertain global climate, which in itself strengthens China's voice in considering the best reforms and policies for these institutions. In the long run, the nature of the BRICS collaboration may inhibit China from becoming a hegemonic revisionist power if China continues to rely on the BRICS collective action for its legitimacy and shield. However, if China acquires more revisionist zeal, and in particular, if it becomes more hegemonic within global financial governance and starts to resemble the United States in this respect, the BRICS collaboration will likely become increasingly difficult.[100]

THE VIEW FROM MOSCOW: RUSSIA'S STRUGGLE FOR AUTONOMY AND INTERNATIONAL INFLUENCE

Since 2006, when President Vladimir Putin proposed transforming the Goldman Sachs investment plan into a diplomatic strategy for the four original BRICs, Russia's interest in developing the BRICS into a significant "Rising Powers Club" has steadily grown.[101] Originally, Russian elites imagined the BRICS as part of a dual strategy of raising Russia's profile and guaranteeing it a voice in all the significant clubs across multiple vectors.[102] In the West, Russia preferred a concert with the major Western powers, particularly the United States, Germany, France, and Italy, but it was consigned to the outer rungs of not-so-special relationships by the North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO) and the European Union (EU), the two dominant Euro-Atlantic institutions.[103] Even its inclusion in the G8 in 1997 (which was suspended in 2014) involved only a partial partnership, as Russia was excluded from most G7 meetings on core financial matters (for its part, China has long declined to be a member). To the East, Russian elites sensed the rise of China and "the rest," but they did not yet appreciate the full measure of the Chinese economic behemoth or the competition that would ensue for regional influence in traditionally Russian spheres, such as Central Asia, or for the status of being the significant counterpart to the United States.[104]